

BOOK ONE OF THREE FREE GUIDES

A FRIENDLY GUIDE FOR THE OVER 50S

AI in Plain English

What AI actually is, what it can do for you, and how to have your very first conversation. No jargon, no rush, no experience needed.

By Joseph Conlan

Clone Centre, Liverpool

CloneCentre

clonecentre.ai

A note from Joseph

Hello, and thank you for picking up this little book.

My name is Joseph Conlan, and I run Clone Centre, an AI consultancy based in Liverpool. I spend my working life helping people and businesses get to grips with artificial intelligence, and I can tell you a secret: most of the people I help start exactly where you might be now. Curious, a bit cautious, and wondering whether any of this is really for them.

It is. I promise.

This book is written for people who did not grow up with computers and have no intention of becoming technical. There is no jargon here, and where a technical word is unavoidable, I explain it in plain English. You do not need to be good with computers. You do not need to remember passwords and codes and commands. You only need to be able to type a sentence, the same way you would write a note to a friend.

Take it slowly. Keep it by the kettle. And when you are ready, try one small thing at a time.

Warm regards,

Joseph Conlan Founder, Clone Centre, Liverpool clonecentre.ai

Chapter 1: What AI actually is

You have heard the term a hundred times by now. AI. Artificial intelligence. It is on the news, in the papers, and half the adverts on the television seem to mention it. But what is it, really?

Here is the simplest honest answer I can give you.

A very well read assistant

Imagine you had an assistant who had read nearly every book, newspaper, recipe card, instruction manual and letter ever written. This assistant never sleeps, never gets impatient, and never minds being asked a silly question. You can ask them anything, in ordinary English, and they will do their best to give you a helpful answer, written just for you, in a few seconds.

That, in essence, is what a modern AI chat is. It is a computer programme that has learned from an enormous amount of written material, and it uses that learning to answer questions, write letters, explain things, make lists, and help with everyday tasks.

It is not magic, and it is not a person

It is worth being clear about two things.

First, AI is not magic, and it is not alive. It does not think or feel the way we do. It is a very clever piece of software that is remarkably good with words. When it writes something that sounds warm or thoughtful, it is because it has learned how warm and thoughtful writing tends to look, not because it has a heart.

Second, it is not perfect. It can make mistakes, and occasionally it states things very confidently that turn out to be wrong. That is why the golden rule of using AI is this: treat it like a helpful friend, not an expert witness. For anything important, such as health, money or legal matters, double check with a real professional. We will come back to this.

It learns from words, not from watching you

A common worry is that the AI is somehow watching you or listening in. It is not. When you open an AI chat, nothing happens until you type something. It answers only what

you ask, using what it learned when it was trained. It does not know who you are unless you tell it, and you should be a little careful about what personal details you share, just as you would with any website. There is a companion book in this series, called Safe and Sound, all about staying safe online.

Why all the fuss now?

Computers that answer questions have existed for years. What is new is how naturally you can talk to them. Until recently, using a computer properly meant learning its language: menus, buttons, commands. Now the computer has learned ours. You type, "Could you write a polite letter to my council about the broken pavement outside my house?" and it simply does it. That change, more than anything, is why AI has suddenly become useful to everyone, not just technical people.

Chapter 2: What it can do, and what it cannot do

What it is genuinely good at

Writing and letters. Drafting a tricky email, a birthday message, a complaint letter, a thank you note, a speech for a wedding. It is excellent at this, and you can ask it to make things longer, shorter, warmer or more formal until it sounds right.

Explaining things. Ask it to explain anything, from inflation to how a heat pump works to what the offside rule is, and ask for it in simple terms. If the first answer is too complicated, say so. "Can you explain that more simply, as if I knew nothing about it?" works wonders.

Planning and lists. Weekly meal plans, packing lists, itineraries for a day out, a rota for who is bringing what to the family gathering.

Ideas and inspiration. Gift ideas for a difficult-to-buy-for grandson. Names for a new allotment society. Ten ways to use up a glut of courgettes.

Summarising. Paste in a long, confusing letter from an insurance company and ask, "What is this actually saying, in plain English?"

Gentle companionship for curious minds. It will happily chat about history, gardening, poetry or old films for as long as you like, at any hour.

What it cannot do

It is not a doctor, solicitor or accountant. It can explain things and help you prepare questions, but for real decisions about your health, your money or the law, you need a qualified human being.

It does not know today's news unless the particular service you are using can look it up. Some AI chats can search the internet, some cannot. Ask, and it will usually tell you.

It cannot guarantee it is right. It occasionally makes things up with great confidence. If a fact really matters, check it.

It cannot ring the bank, post a letter or do anything in the real world. It can only produce words (and sometimes pictures) on your screen.

It should not see your private details. Do not type in passwords, bank details or anything you would not want a stranger to read.

The one rule that matters most

If you remember nothing else from this chapter, remember this: AI is a brilliant first draft and a wonderful explainer, but you stay in charge. You decide what to use, what to ignore, and what to check. It works for you, never the other way round.

Chapter 3: Opening an AI chat for the first time

This is the part that puts most people off, and it is genuinely much easier than it looks. The three best known AI chats at the moment are ChatGPT, Claude and Gemini. They are all good, they all work in almost exactly the same way, and they all have a free option. These steps apply to any of them.

Step 1: Open your web browser

On a computer or tablet, open the same programme you use to look at websites: Safari, Chrome, Edge or whatever you normally use. You do not need to install anything.

Step 2: Go to the website

Type one of these addresses into the address bar at the top: chatgpt.com, claude.ai or gemini.google.com. Any of them will do. If a friend or family member already uses one, use that one, so they can help you.

Step 3: Make a free account

Each service will ask you to sign up. Usually this means giving an email address and choosing a password, or signing in with a Google or Apple account if you have one. Pick the free option. You do not need to pay anything to do everything in this book. If it asks for card details, you have wandered into a paid plan, so go back and choose the free one.

Write your password down somewhere safe at home. A little notebook by the computer is perfectly fine for most people.

Step 4: Find the typing box

You will see a mostly empty screen with a box at the bottom that says something like "Message" or "Ask anything". Click in that box, type a sentence, and press Enter (or tap the arrow button). That is the whole trick. Everything else in this book is just different sentences to type.

Step 5: Have a conversation

The AI will reply, and you can reply back. It remembers what you have said earlier in the same conversation, so you can say things like "make it shorter" or "tell me more about the second one" without repeating yourself. To start a fresh topic, look for a "New chat" button, usually near the top left.

If you get stuck

Ask a younger relative or a friend to sit with you for the first ten minutes. Once you have sent your first message, the nervousness disappears remarkably quickly. It feels, within minutes, like texting a very patient friend.

Chapter 4: Your first ten conversations

Here are ten gentle first conversations to try. Type the words in quotes exactly as they are, or change them to suit yourself. There is no wrong way to do this.

1. The hello. "Hello, this is my first time using an AI chat. I am over 50 and not technical. Please explain, very simply, what kinds of things you can help me with."

2. The letter. "Please write a short, polite letter to my GP surgery asking for a repeat prescription. Leave spaces for my name and address."

3. The explainer. "Explain what inflation means, in plain English, in two short paragraphs, for someone who is not interested in economics."

4. The meal plan. "Plan five simple evening meals for one person. I like traditional British food, nothing too spicy. Give me a shopping list too."

5. The gift hunt. "My granddaughter is eleven and loves horses and drawing. Suggest eight birthday presents under twenty pounds."

6. The confusing document. Paste in any baffling letter or email and add: "Please explain what this is asking me to do, in plain English."

7. The day out. "Plan a relaxed day out in my area for two people in their sixties. Somewhere with a nice lunch and not too much walking." (Tell it your town.)

8. The hobby helper. "I want to start growing tomatoes for the first time. Explain the very basics, month by month, for a beginner with a small garden."

9. The wording wizard. "My neighbour's tree is damaging my fence. Write a friendly note I could put through their door, keeping things pleasant."

10. The just-for-fun chat. "Tell me something fascinating about the history of my home town." (Name your town, then follow up with "tell me more" as often as you like.)

When you have tried these, you will have the hang of it. The companion book in this series, *Everyday AI*, has fifty more ideas, each with the exact words to type.

Chapter 5: The jargon buster

New words are half the battle with technology. Here are the ones you will actually hear, explained properly.

AI (artificial intelligence). Computer software that can do things that used to need a human mind, such as understanding and writing natural language.

AI chat or chatbot. A programme you have a typed conversation with. ChatGPT, Claude and Gemini are all AI chats.

Prompt. Simply the thing you type into the chat. Your question or instruction. "Write a poem about my dog" is a prompt.

App. Short for application. A programme on your phone, tablet or computer.

Browser. The programme you use to visit websites, such as Safari, Chrome or Edge.

Account. Your personal registration with a website, usually an email address and a password, so it remembers you.

Sign up and log in. Signing up is registering for the first time. Logging in is proving it is you on later visits, normally with your password.

Password manager. An optional programme that remembers your passwords for you. Handy, but a notebook kept safely at home works too.

Free tier. The free version of a service. Companies offer paid versions with extras, but the free tier is all you need to begin.

Model. The particular version of the AI you are talking to. Companies release improved models from time to time. You do not need to do anything about it.

Hallucination. The awkward term for when an AI confidently states something that is not true. It does not happen often, but it is why we double check important facts.

Data. Information. Your messages, your account details, anything the computer stores.

Privacy settings. The controls a website gives you over what it does with your information. Worth a look once, or ask a family member to help.

Two factor authentication (2FA). An extra security step where the site sends a code to your phone as well as asking for a password. A very good idea for email and banking.

Phishing. A scam message pretending to be from a real company, trying to get your details. The Safe and Sound book in this series covers this properly.

Algorithm. A set of rules a computer follows. When people say "the algorithm showed me that video", they mean the computer's rules chose it for them.

The cloud. A grand name for computers in a data centre somewhere that store things for you, so you can reach them from any device.

Update. A newer version of an app or programme. Generally sensible to accept them, as they fix security problems.

Spam. Unwanted junk messages. Delete without clicking anything in them.

Link. Text or a picture you click to go to another page. Only click links you were expecting.

Download. To copy something from the internet onto your device. Upload is the opposite: copying from your device to the internet.

And that is genuinely most of it. When someone uses a technical word you do not know, remember you now own an assistant who will explain anything: open your AI chat and type "What does that word mean, in plain English?"

About Clone Centre

Clone Centre is an independent AI consultancy based in Liverpool, founded by Joseph Conlan.

We help ordinary people and small organisations understand and use artificial intelligence, without the jargon and without the hard sell. That includes friendly training sessions, one to one help getting set up, and practical advice for small businesses wondering what AI could actually do for them.

If you enjoyed this book, you may like the other two in the series: Everyday AI: 50 Simple Ways It Can Help Around the House and Beyond, and Safe and Sound: How to Spot AI Scams and Protect Yourself Online.

You can find us, and get in touch, at **clonecentre.ai**.

AI should work for everyone. We would be glad to help you make it work for you.